

shelters (SHILA) to combat the harsh winter conditions. In addition, about 450 technical storages were built to house armoured vehicles and weaponry systems and protect them from the intense cold.

CHINESE ADVANCES

Much of India's frenetic activity along the LAC and in the Northeast is in response to China's infrastructural advances in its Tibet Autonomous Region (TAR), including an extensive rail network and roads spanning over 60,000 km. Last year, China launched a bullet train connecting Lhasa with Nyingchi, a town opposite India's Tuting sector in the Upper Siang district of Arunachal Pradesh, and only 40 kms away from the border. PLA's 52nd and 53rd mountain infantry brigades are based in the larger Nyingchi Prefecture. Further north, the 1,600 km-long Sichuan-Tibet rail line will link Lhasa on the Tibetan Plateau with Chengdu in central Sichuan. Military observers claim that the total road network in Tibet has increased from 7,300 km in 1959 to 118,800 km in 2021—an astounding expansion of 4.93 km a day.

The PLA has built at least eight roads towards the LAC from China's G219 highway, including one connecting it with Sirijap at Finger 8 on the Pangong Tso lake. In addition, a highway connects Rutog County in TAR to Spanggur lake south of Pangong Tso. Another road runs from the south of Shiquanhe in Tibet's Ngari prefecture to Chumar in eastern Ladakh. These new roads will ensure that China will have direct road connectivity to areas opposite important Indian military posts along the LAC, from DBO in the north to the Galwan Valley, Pangong Tso and Chumar in the south.

Experts feel that steady improvements in Chinese infrastructure are indicative of intentions to maintain an entrenched presence, and suggest that the continuing disengagement process has its limits, particularly in the absence of a substantive change in China's posture. US Army Pacific Command's General Charles A. Flynn, during his visit to New Delhi in June this year, had said that "some of the infrastructure being created in the Western Theatre Command is alarming".

SLOW AWAKENING

Now that the military and the Centre realise the full import of China's activity, funds are being allocated at a much faster pace to develop roads, airfields and helipads, notes Lt Gen. Hooda. "We always lagged behind in infrastructure development along the LAC, so at least some gaps are now getting filled up. Terrain in the Tibet plateau gives an advantage to PLA, but our weaknesses are being remedied slowly," he says. With a large number of troops being deployed at the LAC, which is no longer a peaceful border, better infrastructure is a must to keep them supplied and in a fighting fit condition, he adds.

Flawed strategic decisions of the past are also to blame for the slow pace of Indian infrastructure development. For years, Indian policymakers neglected the China border because of a misguided strategy that believed that the primitive state of infrastructure on the Indian side "would be a deterrent to enemies". Thus, road connectivity was deliberately neglected. Former defence minister A.K. Antony had accepted this to be an "incorrect approach" and declared a "turnaround in government policy" to build/ upgrade infrastructure. However, it was under the Modi government that development accelerated, with the BRO's budget increasing steadily. From 2008 to 2016, it hovered between Rs 3,300 crore and Rs 4,600 crore, but shot up to Rs 8,050 crore in the 2018-19 Union budget.

For years, India neglected the China border because of a flawed strategy that poor infrastructure "would be a deterrent to enemies"

Early on during the face-off between the Indian Army and the PLA in Ladakh, in May 2020, the Union government had accepted and implemented the recommendations of the committee of experts headed by Lt Gen. D.B. Shekatkar (retd) on border infrastructure. These were related to speeding up road construction, for socio-economic development in border areas. Introduction of modern construction plants and machinery was given importance, for which the expert panel recommended increased powers to the BRO to procure them. Since construction of infrastructure on the